Lesson 36: Grammar: Simple Future

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 10.4: Grammar Presentation-Simple Future; 10.5: Communication Practice.

In this lesson

In Lesson 34 you learned how to form will and be going to, when to choose each one, and how to write future time clauses. This lesson adds the full sentence patterns: negatives, yes/no questions, short answers and information questions. You will also decide whether a present verb is about present or future time, and make predictions and plans with your tutor. Correct questions and short answers matter in interviews, surveys and class discussions.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Make negative statements, yes/no questions, short answers and information questions with will and be going to.
- Use will for predictions, volunteering, promises and quick decisions, and be going to for predictions and plans.
- Tell whether a simple present or present progressive sentence is about present or future time.
- Make predictions about everyday situations and about the future of a college.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
statement	a sentence that gives information (not a question)	Ivana is going to take classes next semester.
negative statement	a statement with not	The population will not grow slowly.
contraction	a short form with an apostrophe	won't = will not; I'll = I will; isn't = is not
yes/no question	a question you answer with yes or no	Will the population grow slowly?
short answer	Yes or No + pronoun + will / won't / be	Yes, it will. No, she isn't.
information question	a question that starts with a question word (where, when, why, how, what)	Why will the population grow slowly?
pre·DIC·tion	a guess about the future	The event is going to be a success!
vol·un·TEER·ing	offering to do something	I will help you study for the exam.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
promise	saying that you will certainly do something	I will take out the trash after dinner. I promise!
quick decision	a decision made at the moment of speaking	Is the movie at 5PM or 7:30PM? Ok, I'll go!
SCHED·ule / timetable	a list of the times when events happen	The movie starts at 8:30PM.
ar·RANGE·ment	a plan for a certain time and place, often made with another person	I am receiving tutoring tomorrow in the library.

Rules and explanations

Four ways to talk about the future

- Simple future with will: The population will grow slowly.
- Simple future with be going to: The population is going to be more diverse.
- Simple present: The class begins at 8:00AM tomorrow.
- Present progressive: The bus is leaving the station at 7:30PM this evening.

Will: patterns

Sentence type	Pattern	Example
Statement	Subject + will + base verb	The population will grow slowly.
Negative	Subject + will not (won't) + base verb	The population will not grow slowly.
Yes/no question	Will + subject + base verb?	Will the population grow slowly?
Short answers	Yes, pronoun + will. / No, pronoun + won't.	Yes, it will. / No, it won't.
Information question	Question word + will + subject + base verb?	Why will the population grow slowly?

- Will never changes: no "wills", no -s on the verb after it, and the negative contraction is won't.
- In a short answer with yes, do not contract: "Yes, it will." The contraction 'll is fine inside a sentence: "Ok, I'll go!"

Will: purposes

- Predictions: It is estimated that in 2030, the baby boomers will be over age 65.
- Volunteering: I will help you study for the exam.
- Promises: I will take out the trash after dinner. I promise!
- Quick decisions: Is the movie at 5PM or 7:30PM? Ok, I'll go!

Be going to: patterns

Sentence type	Pattern	Example
Statement	Subject + be going to + base verb	Ivana is going to take classes next semester.
Negative	Subject + be not going to + base verb	Ivana is not going to take classes next semester.
Yes/no question	Be verb + subject + going to + base verb?	Is Ivana going to take classes next semester?
Short answers	Yes, pronoun + be verb. / No, pronoun + be verb + not (contraction).	Yes, she is. / No, she isn't.
Information question	Question word + be verb + subject + going to + base verb?	Where is Ivana going to take classes next semester?

- The be verb (am, is, are) agrees with the subject and moves before the subject in questions. Never add do or does: the question is made with be.
- After going to, use the base verb (no -s, no -ed).

Be going to: purposes

- Prediction: The event is going to be a success!
- Plans: I am going to visit my grandparents on Sunday.

These purposes match Lesson 34: both forms can predict; will is for decisions made at the moment of speaking and for promises; be going to is for plans made before.

Present forms with a future meaning

- Simple present for a schedule or timetable: The movie starts at 8:30PM.
- Present progressive for a future arrangement: I am receiving tutoring tomorrow in the library.
- Present or future? Look for a future time expression (tomorrow, this evening, next semester) or a schedule. Without them, a present verb usually talks about present time.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic questions keep the word order of a statement, so learners often write "What you will study next year?" In English, put will or the be verb before the subject: "What will you study next year?" / "What are you going to study next year?"

Practice

Exercise 3. Simple Future-Will. Complete the sentences and questions using the simple future will.

1. Watch out! You _____ hurt! a) 'll get b) 'll gets
2. When _____ available to meet with me? a) will you are b) you will be c) will you be
3. _____ online or in-person? a) Will the class be b) Wills the class be c) Will the class is

4. The class _____ on January 7th. a) will begins b) will begin c) wills begin
5. I _____ anymore cupcakes. a) won't eat b) won't eats c) willn't eat
6. The cases _____ after the holidays. a) will decreases b) will decrease
7. People _____ more time off. a) wills take b) will takes c) will take
8. Will you be at school tomorrow? Yes, _____. a) I'll b) I won't c) I will
9. Will she arrive tonight? Yes, _____. a) she'll b) she wills c) she will
10. Where _____ place? a) will take the wedding b) will the wedding take c) the wedding will take

Exercise 4. Be Going to Statements. Use the words to create sentences with be going to. Example: graduate/in June/Rashid/be going to → Rashid is going to graduate in June.

1. Julia/visit/be going to/her parents
2. Tuesday/be going to/David/send/the letter
3. be going to/next semester/Ms. Hess/this class/teach
4. see/be going to/I/him/at the meeting
5. tomorrow/sunny/be going to/It/be

Exercise 5. Be Going to Questions. Complete the questions using be going to.

1. Why _____ late? a) is he going to be b) he is going to be
2. When _____ in Italy? a) you are going to arrive b) are you going to arrive
3. _____ married this summer? a) Is he going to gets b) He is going to get c) Is he going to get
4. How _____ for the next exam? a) are you going to study b) do you going to studied c) you are going to study
5. What _____ after class? a) is Martin going to do b) is Martin going to does c) does Martin going to do
6. How _____ the economy? a) does the politician going to fix b) is the politician going to fix c) the politician is going to fix
7. When _____ a break? a) we are going to take b) are we going to take c) do we going to take
8. When _____ the doctor? (numbered 7 again in the book; the key calls it 8) a) am I going to see b) I am going to see

Exercise 6. Present or Future. Is the sentence expressing present time or future time? Choose a) present or b) future.

1. I am giving Socorra a Peppa Pig gift for her birthday.
2. The teacher is talking. Don't interrupt!
3. Andrea is taking four classes next semester.
4. The class ends at 11:50AM.
5. Haifa returns to California in August.

6. She studies biology.
7. Hussain plans to marry next year.
8. They are traveling to Bolivia after the semester.
9. I graduate in May.
10. Tony is meeting his instructor during office hours.

Exercise 8. Story Predictions. Read the scenarios. Make predictions with will or be going to about what will happen next. Example: Allison signed up to bring 4 dozen cookies to her daughter's class. "I think she's going to purchase them at a bakery." "I think she will bake them."

1. You're starting to feel sick.
2. Your teacher gave you an exam study guide.
3. Your brother's car broke, and he needs to go to work.
4. Your friend wants to learn English.
5. Your family wants to move into a bigger home.
6. It's your friend's birthday Saturday.
7. Your phone's screen has a crack.

Speak with your tutor

- "Let's plan my next vacation together (Exercise 7). Agree on a destination with me, then plan places to see and activities to do. I will use will, be going to, the simple present and the present progressive. Correct my future forms."
- "Ask me the five survey questions in Exercise 10, one at a time, starting with 'What are you going to do after class?' I will answer with a future verb. Then I will ask you the same questions."
- "Give me small problems, for example 'I can't carry all these books.' I will answer with a quick decision, an offer to help or a promise with will."
- "Ask me ten yes/no questions with will and be going to about my week. I will give short answers. Then ask me five information questions."

Read aloud

Rising intonation (↗) for yes/no questions, falling (↘) for information questions. Won't is /woʊnt/, not "want" /wɑnt/.

- Will the population grow slowly? (↗) Yes, it will. No, it won't.
- Why will the population grow slowly? (↘)
- Is Ivana going to take classes next semester? (↗) Yes, she is. No, she isn't.
- Where is Ivana going to take classes next semester? (↘)
- Is the movie at 5PM or 7:30PM? Ok, I'll go!
- I am receiving tutoring tomorrow in the library.

Writing task

Book Exercise 9, Predictions about College. What will your college or university be like in 2050? Write a paragraph of 8 to 10 sentences with at least five predictions. What will change? What will be the same? Think about the buildings, services and instruction (how classes are taught).

- Start with a topic sentence, for example: "By 2050, my university will be very different from today."
- Use will and be going to, at least one negative (won't, isn't going to) and one future time clause (Lesson 34).

Self-editing checklist:

- Will is followed by a base verb, never by -s or -ing.
- Every going to has am, is or are before it.
- Negatives: won't + base verb; am/is/are not going to + base verb.
- Any questions use question word order (will or be before the subject).
- The time clause has a present verb.
- Each prediction has a reason or an example.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 3 (book)

1. a) 'll get
2. c) will you be
3. a) Will the class be
4. b) will begin
5. a) won't eat (the usual spelling is "any more cupcakes")
6. b) will decrease
7. c) will take
8. c) I will (no contraction at the end of a short answer)
9. c) she will
10. b) will the wedding take

Exercise 4 (book)

1. Julia is going to visit her parents.
2. David is going to send the letter Tuesday. ("on Tuesday" is also correct)
3. Ms. Hess is going to teach this class next semester.
4. I am going to see him at the meeting.
5. It is going to be sunny tomorrow.

Exercise 5 (book)

1. a) is he going to be
2. b) are you going to arrive
3. c) Is he going to get
4. a) are you going to study
5. a) is Martin going to do
6. b) is the politician going to fix
7. b) are we going to take
8. a) am I going to see

Exercise 6 (book)

1. b) future (an arrangement: for her birthday)
2. a) present (happening now)
3. b) future (next semester)
4. b) future (a timetable)
5. b) future (a schedule: in August)
6. a) present

7. b) future ("plans" is present, but the marriage is next year)
8. b) future (after the semester)
9. b) future (a schedule: in May)
10. b) future (an arrangement)

Items 4 and 10 have no future time word: the book reads them as a timetable and an arrangement. Without context, they could also describe the present (every class day; right now).

Exercise 8 (example answers)

1. I think I'm going to stay home tomorrow. I will drink some hot tea and go to bed early.
2. I think I'm going to study it this weekend. I will probably do well on the exam.
3. I think he's going to take the bus. He will probably ask me for a ride.
4. I think she's going to take a class at a community college. She will practice every day.
5. I think they're going to look for a house this summer. They will probably sell the old one first.
6. I think we're going to have a party for her. I will buy her a cake.
7. I think the crack is going to get bigger. I will take my phone to a repair shop.

My notes